the extremists of both the settler and Haredi camps. At the time, the justice minister who supported Aharon Barak was Likud member Dan Meridor, and, a few years later, Netanyahu also expressed himself in favor of such liberal legislation.

Netanyahu's personal troubles with the Justice Ministry and the growth of the settler movement and the ultrareligious community changed the picture and led a politician desperately attempting to escape condemnation for a series of alleged misdeeds to link up with the only constituencies that shared an interest in overcoming the court's authority. This strategy brought about the present coalition and its program for judicial overhaul.

If one takes into account the wider state of Israeli society, beyond the structure of the judiciary and its powers, then a far deeper rift has to be taken into account: the rift between Mizrahim and Ashkenazim, mentioned here on several occasions. The dismissal of Aryeh Deri from his ministerial appointments and the specific overhaul measures aiming at his reinstatement are partly an expression of this. Let's remember: Shas, of which Deri is the uncontested leader, is altogether nationalist, ultra-Orthodox, and Mizrahi (Sephardi) by definition. Moreover, some of its most vocal Knesset members, such as David Amsalem, nurse a violent anti-Ashkenazi resentment; it is a widespread undercurrent that influenced the electoral results.

As I previously mentioned, the expenses of the Netanyahu family, including two private homes and all hosting expenses, are covered by public funds, without any transparency obligation. There is nothing like this among major Western democracies, according to an Israeli research center.

Saturday, March 11

The terror attack in Tel Aviv and the deepening crisis did not deter the Netanyahus from spending the weekend in Rome. Sara'le probably wants to